Bollywood and cricket personalities prefer to engage with less political content online. Modi made adroit use of this by engaging celebrities through challenges like the #SwacchBharat campaign, the Fitness Challenge or with his #SelfieWithModi campaign.[58]

Why Digital and Ground Campaigning Can't Be Differentiated Anymore

When the Congress Curiously Reduced Digital Advertising

The Congress did not lose only because it was outgunned on digital media. While the BJP remained dominant on social-media platforms, the Congress had put up a fight online. It lost also because of other reasons that had to do with the party's larger strategy, tactics and messaging. That said, in the last month of the 2019 general election campaign, the digital advertising trail shows a dipping trend for the Congress, which is curious. On Google, from sometime around 22 April 2019, a full month before the election campaign ended, Congress's spending on digital media dropped sharply (see Figure 7.6). While spending by the BJP also dipped after April—since only the last three phases of the seven-stage campaign were left—the Congress dip was much sharper. This is particularly inexplicable because these last phases included constituencies in states where the Congress was in a direct one-to-one fight with the BJP or its allies: Madhya Pradesh, Rajasthan, Haryana, Punjab and Himachal Pradesh. Also, while BJP's spending saw an uptick in the final week of the campaign, Congress's spending dropped even faster in this last phase.

Figure 7.6: Political Advertising Trend on Google by BJP and Congress in 2019 Elections[59]

Google Advertising Volumes and Money Spent by BJP and Congress (2018-19)

Party Name	*Digital Advertisements*	*Amount Spent*
BJP	12,014	18,30,36,750